Lessons

Basic Conversions

Sometimes measurements need to be written in larger or smaller units. Use your common sense to choose an operation. Remember, multiplication generally makes more things. Division makes fewer things.

Smaller to Larger Units ÷	Larger to Smaller Units ×

Example 1

Hide

Marla wonders if the couch she wants to buy will fit against a wall that is 7 ft long. The couch is 76 in long. Convert its length to feet and inches.

Step 1
Set up the problem.
76 in = _____ ft _____ in

Step 2
Divide by the number of smaller units.
(12 in = 1 ft)
76 in ÷ 12 = 6 R4

6'4" < 7'

Step 3
Write the whole number as the larger unit and the remainder as the smaller unit.
76 in = **6 ft 4 in**
6 ft 4 in is less than 7 ft. The couch will fit against the wall.

Example 2

Hide

Roberta needed $6\frac{1}{4}$ feet of material for a window covering. How many inches of material does she need?

Step 1
Set up the problem.
$6\frac{1}{4}$ ft = _____ in

$\frac{25}{4}$ ~~feet~~ × 12 $\frac{\text{inches}}{\text{~~foot~~}}$ = 75 inches

Step 2
Multiply by the number of smaller units.
$6\frac{1}{4} \times 12 = \frac{25}{\cancel{4}_{1}} \times \frac{\cancel{12}^{3}}{1} = 75$ in

$6\frac{1}{4} = \frac{4\times6+1}{4}$

$= \frac{25}{4}$

Roberta will need **75 inches** of material.

Example 3

Hide

Jim has 47 fl oz of juice left in a carton. Express this amount in cups and fluid ounces.

Step 1
Set up the problem.
47 fl oz = _____ c _____ fl oz

Step 2
To change to a larger unit, divide by the number of smaller units.
(8 fl oz = 1 c)
47 fl oz ÷ 8 = 5 R7

Step 3
Write the whole number as the larger unit and the remainder as the smaller unit.
47 fl oz = 5 c 7 fl oz
Jim has **5 c 7 fl oz** of juice.

Example 4

Hide

Soo Jung has $1\frac{1}{4}$ qt of applesauce. She needs 38 fl oz. Does she have enough?

Step 1
Set up the problem.
$1\frac{1}{4}$ qt = _____ fl oz

1 quart = 2 pints
2 pints = 4 cups
4 cups = 32 fluid ounces

Step 2
Find out how many fluid ounces there are in 1 qt.
1 qt = 2 pt
2 pt = 4 c
4 c = 32 fl oz

$\frac{5}{4}$ ~~qt~~ × 32 $\frac{\text{fl oz}}{\text{~~qt~~}}$ = $\frac{160}{4}$ = 40 fl oz.

Step 3
To change to a smaller unit, multiply by the number of smaller units (1 qt = 32 fl oz).
$1\frac{1}{4} \times 32 = \frac{5}{4} \times \frac{32}{1} = 40$ fl oz
Yes, Soo Jung has enough applesauce (40 fl oz).

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Lesson 1: Customary Units of Measurement

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